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Report Name: China's Priorities in Agriculture and Rural Development in 2026

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Report Highlights:

On February 3, 2026, Beijing released the annual No. 1 Document, outlining national strategies and measures related to agriculture and rural development. While food security remains the top priority, the focus has shifted from pursuing quantity increases to striving for improvements in quality. The document highlights the adoption of “new productive forces” such as artificial intelligence and robotics in agriculture. Additionally, it reiterates diversifying import sources and stresses the importance of coordinating agricultural imports with domestic production.

Statement

FAS China provides this reporting and analysis as a service to U.S. farmers, ranchers, rural communities, and agribusinesses in support of a worldwide agricultural information system and a level playing field for U.S. agriculture.

Background

Each year, the Chinese Communist Party Central Committee and the State Council issue their No. 1 Document, a policy blueprint on agriculture and rural development that shapes China's approach to food security and rural development. This report details new policies, changes in existing policies, and highlights the overall strategy laid out in the report, which can directly impact future trade policy decisions. While the No. 1 Document communicates important changes in policy direction that influence the behavior of Chinese government officials, it does not directly address funding levels or provide implementing regulations.

Food Security Remains a Central Priority

For many years, food security has remained the top priority of the country's agricultural strategy. The central government has focused on efforts to increase grain production through various policies such as ensuring adequate acreage for grain production, seed development, subsidies to grain farmers, procurement price support, soil improvement, and most recently, an action plan to improve grain production capacity by another 50 million metric tons (MMT). Consequently, China's grain output has reached 700 MMT for two consecutive years in 2024 and 2025.

However, in recent years, China's definition of "food security" has expanded beyond staple grains to encompass feed crops (particularly oilseeds), animal protein (especially pork), and increasingly, diversified food sources from forestry and ocean resources. Given constraints in land and water resources, agricultural imports, especially imports of feed materials and animal protein, have remained an important component of meeting domestic demand. In 2025, China was the second largest global buyer of agricultural products, with imports reaching \$207 billion.

Rural Development and the Agricultural Modernization Agenda

After declaring victory over absolute poverty in 2020, Beijing established a five-year transition period through 2025 to prevent rural populations from backsliding into poverty. This focus on rural income stability influences agricultural policy decisions and can affect import patterns, particularly when domestic producer interests' conflict with consumer demand for affordable, high-quality imported products.

In recent years, the No. 1 Documents have placed increasing importance on achieving a "strong agricultural nation," also called "agricultural modernization." In addition to upgrading agricultural production, Beijing has deployed more policies to support rural governance, infrastructure, industries, and public services.

Analysis of Policy Priorities in the 2026 No. 1 Document

Released as China enters its 15th Five-Year Plan (2026-2030), and the first year after a 5-year transition period for consolidating the achievements of poverty alleviation, [the 2026 No. 1 Document](#), titled “Opinions of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of China and the State Council on Anchoring Agricultural and Rural Modernization and Steadily Promoting the Comprehensive Revitalization of Rural Areas,” signals both continuity and evolution in Beijing’s agricultural strategy. While maintaining traditional emphases on food security and rural development, the document introduces new concepts that will shape market conditions for U.S. agricultural exporters over the coming years.

Food Security: Intensified Self-Sufficiency Drive with Continued Import Dependence

Production Targets and Quality Improvement: The 2026 document establishes a new objective of maintaining grain production at approximately 700 MMT (50 MMT higher than the prior target of 650 MMT) through a three-pillar approach: stabilizing acreage, increasing yields, and optimizing structure. As part of the action plan launched in 2024 to increase grain production capacity, provincial governments must increase per-capita yields of major grain and oilseed crops through integrated deployment of high-quality farmland, improved seeds, advanced machinery, and effective farming practices. Notably, the document emphasizes optimizing planting patterns and promoting market-favored grain varieties to capture premium prices. For oilseeds specifically, it calls for enhanced soybean production capacity while expanding cultivation of rapeseed, peanuts, and camellia oleifera.

Farmland Protection and Upgrade: The document intensifies its language around enforcement of the 120-million-hectare arable land “red line” through stricter penalties for illegal occupation, crackdowns on farmland destruction, and restoration of fallow land. It supports continued construction of high-standard farmland with differentiated approaches by location and land type, coupled with modernized irrigation systems. The document calls for an improved mechanism for maintaining the “permanent basic farmland” by replacing inferior land with higher quality land. New initiatives include black soil protection projects and comprehensive utilization of saline-alkali and acidified land.

Risk Prevention and Mitigation: The document establishes an “Agricultural Resilience and Disaster Mitigation Network” to safeguard rural productivity against natural disasters and market volatility. This comprehensive prevention and control system prioritizes monitoring and early warning systems for meteorological and hydrological risks, supported by detailed surveys and zoning of agricultural climate resources. To enhance physical infrastructure, the framework calls for renovation of irrigation systems and development of emergency water sources for drought relief. It streamlines procedures for the emergency deployment of relief equipment and strengthens joint efforts to control major pest and disease outbreaks, ensuring coordinated response to environmental threats.

Diversified Food Sources: Continuing the shift from “single source of grains” to a “balanced approach encompassing crops, forestry, husbandry, and fisheries,” the document addresses livestock production challenges. It proposes comprehensive control of hog production capacity

and consolidating the achievements made through government support to the cattle and dairy industries in previous year. (Note: Affected by high feed costs and low meat and milk prices, beef and dairy cattle farming suffered losses. The government provided relief through fiscal subsidies, financial support, and policies to stabilize prices and ensure supply. Currently, beef cattle farming has shown signs of improved profitability in some regions; losses in the dairy cattle sector have narrowed, though the sector remains under pressure; and raw milk prices have generally stabilized at relatively low levels.) The document also supports production of silage corn and alfalfa for animal feed, promotes offshore and deep-sea aquaculture, and encourages development of forest foods (i.e. mushrooms), biological agriculture, and greenhouse agriculture.

Farmer Support Mechanisms: To safeguard the livelihoods of grain farmers, the document outlines a comprehensive support framework integrating price stabilization (minimum purchase prices for rice and wheat and refines target price policies for cotton), direct subsidies (land fertility protection, machinery purchase, corn and soybean production), and robust insurance coverage. It calls for implementing the inter-provincial compensation mechanism introduced in 2024, requiring grain-consuming provinces to invest in grain-producing provinces and proposes and guides agri-businesses to develop grain processing facilities.

Agricultural Trade: Balancing Imports with Domestic Protection

The document explicitly acknowledges the important role of agricultural imports. This ties in with remarks from the Minister of Agriculture and Rural Affairs who noted that imports of soybeans, meat, dairy products, fresh and dried fruit, and wine have filled the structural gaps in supply and demand in the domestic market. However, the 2026 report introduces a significant new directive: “coordinating agricultural imports with domestic production,” meaning China will manage the pace and volume of imports to ensure food security and protect domestic industries and markets. The document reiterates the importance of diversifying import sources to avoid over-dependence on limited suppliers. Simultaneously, it calls for developing internationally competitive Chinese agricultural enterprises to enhance participation in global supply chains.

Agricultural Modernization Through “New Productive Forces”

For the first time, the 2026 document explicitly proposes “building agriculture into a modernized large-scale industry” centered on new technologies and intelligent machinery, while previous documents emphasized “rural industrial revitalization” and “developing specialty rural industries.” The document establishes a full-chain technology support system encompassing innovation, application, and transformation, with focus on:

- Accelerating selection and promotion of critical seed varieties and promoting the commercialization of biotech seed breeding
- Addressing shortages of intelligent agricultural machinery for hilly and mountainous areas
- Integrating artificial intelligence with agricultural development
- Expanding application of drones, Internet of Things, and robotics

Land Reform and Investment Mechanisms

The document expands a province-wide pilot program extending land contracts for another 30 years upon expiration, designed to maintain long-term stability in rural land management while protecting farmers' land rights. It prioritizes use of collectively owned construction land for industrial growth and facilitates the “two-way flow” of resources and talent between urban and rural areas. New investment and financing mechanisms prioritize fiscal support through super-long-term special treasury bonds and establishment of a rural revitalization infrastructure fund. The framework introduces specialized financial products including agricultural facility mortgages and insurance policy financing.

Rural Development: Modern Living Conditions as Core Objective

The 2026 document marks a strategic shift by establishing “ensuring rural areas have basic modern living conditions” as its primary objective. Unlike previous policies addressing isolated infrastructure tasks, this framework emphasizes comprehensive improvement in three areas: completeness of rural infrastructure, convenience of public services, and comfort of the rural living environment.

The framework introduces “categorized and orderly, regionalized promotion” adapting to rural-to-urban migration trends, aiming to optimize village layouts and avoid ineffective investment. It addresses critical infrastructure shortcomings including high logistics costs and poor network coverage, while modernizing public services through programs like deploying college graduates as rural doctors and creating urban-rural school and medical consortia.

The final focus of the framework is the long-term management and maintenance of the rural living environment. For the first time, there is a dedicated emphasis on socialized maintenance systems for rural toilets and the coordinated treatment of domestic sewage and waste. By promoting waste reduction at the source, the policy seeks to eliminate persistent issues like “black and odorous water” and garbage accumulation, ensuring that environmental improvements are both effective and sustainable over the long term.

Poverty Alleviation from Transitional to Standardized Assistance

The framework introduces a standardized assistance mechanism to sustain poverty alleviation achievements through dynamic management covering the entire rural population, refined assistance integrating industry development with social safety nets, and consistent policies through stable fiscal investment. It establishes “tiered and categorized assistance” prioritizing resources for specifically identified underdeveloped counties.

Farmer Income Enhancement Strategy

The document outlines a comprehensive strategy strengthening county-level industries through sustainable agricultural production, deep processing of goods, and agricultural brand development. It emphasizes rural e-commerce development and construction of warehousing and preservation facilities near production sites. The document places significant focus on protecting

migrant workers' rights, ensuring timely wage payments, and supporting those returning to rural areas. The proposal would enhance farmer livelihoods through vocational skills training, expanding property income via idle land use, and diversifying rural industries by upgrading tourism and cultural offerings.

Conclusion

The 2026 No. 1 Document signals both continuity and evolution in China's agricultural strategy as it enters the 15th Five-Year Plan period (2026-2030). While maintaining traditional emphases on food security through increased domestic production, the document introduces new concepts including "coordinating agricultural imports with domestic production" and "building agriculture into a modernized large-scale industry" centered on new technologies. The framework establishes "ensuring rural areas have basic modern living conditions" as a primary objective, marking a strategic shift toward comprehensive rural development beyond isolated infrastructure improvements. These policies will shape China's agricultural sector and trade patterns throughout the coming five-year period, with implementation details and practical effects requiring continued monitoring.

Attachments:

No Attachments.